Stages of Foetal Growth During Gestation

Prenatal development: about 38 weeks from fertilization (40 weeks from LMP)

1. Germinal Stage (Weeks 1-2)

- The zygote forms at fertilization, then divides into a morula and a blastocyst.
- The blastocyst implants in the uterine wall around day 6-10.

2. Embryonic Stage (Weeks 3-8)

- The three germ layers form: ectoderm, mesoderm and endoderm.
- Organogenesis occurs: the neural tube, heart (beating by about week 5), limb buds, eyes and ears develop.
- This is the most vulnerable period for teratogens (e.g., thalidomide).

3. Foetal Stage (Week 9 to Birth)

Weeks	Key developments
9-12	External genitalia differentiate, and the fetus begins to move.
13-16	Skeleton ossifies, and the fetus is about 10-12 cm long.
17-20	Quickening (the mother feels movement); lanugo and vernix appear.
21-24	Lungs begin producing surfactant; viability begins around week 24.
25-28	Eyes open, and the nervous system matures rapidly.
29-36	Rapid weight gain through fat deposition; lung maturation continues.
37-40	Full term; the head usually engages in the pelvis.

By Trimester

Trimester	Weeks	Focus
1st	1-12	Organ formation
2nd	13-27	Growth and movement
3rd	28-40	Maturation and weight gain